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How Did This Mulligan Thing Start?



So you might be thinking the Mulligan started in Ireland since it's an Irish name, but that doesn't appear to be the case. There are two popular theories, but it doesn't seem like the term became commonplace until several decades after the golfers named Mulligan played the game.

One was a Canadian golfer named David Mulligan, who played at the Country Club of Montreal back in the 1920s. Legend has it that David Mulligan, who was a bit jumpy or nervous on the first tee, hit a poor tee shot, re-teed, and hit another, calling the second one a "correction shot." He eventually brought the concept to the storied Winged Foot Golf Club in Mamaroneck, N.Y.

Another theory has this practice named after John "Buddy" Mulligan, who was a locker room attendant at Essex Fells Country Club in New Jersey back in the 1930s. The story goes that after he would finish cleaning the locker room, he would play a round with the assistant pro and a member or two. Because they were able to practice before their round, and he wasn't, he believed he was entitled to an extra shot if he needed it when the round began. He would tell the members about his privilege, and the members started putting the practice in play as well, referring to the do-over as a Mulligan.